

Olson on Animalism

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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Animalism

MY FAMILY AND OTHER ANIMALS

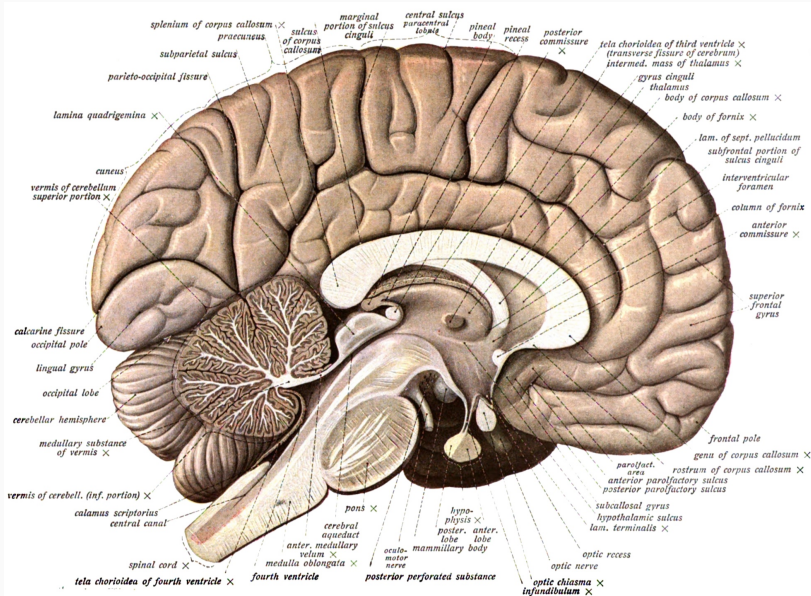


Cerebrum transplantation

A widely discussed science fiction scenario: scientists discover a way to transplant a *cerebrum* from one body into another, regrowing all the neural connections required for normal functioning.

Note: the *cerebrum* is the largest part of your brain, including everything except for the *cerebellum* and *brainstem*. (In most discussions of this sort of case in the literature, it's the whole brain that is transplanted; but for reasons we need not go into, Olson thinks it's cleaner to focus on cases where it's just the cerebrum.)

After such a procedure, there will be a person who *looks* just like the recipient, but *thinks* just like the donor (including memories and all the rest). Given their memories, this person will be naturally inclined to say 'I am the donor, and now I have a new body'. Are they right?



Cerebrum transplantation with nonhuman animals

What do we think would happen if the cerebrum transplantation operation were performed on *cats*? Would the cat go with its cerebrum, or with the remainder?

What about fish?

What about bees? (Apparently they have a 'protocerebrum', a 'deutocerebrum', and a 'tritocerebrum' instead of a single cerebrum.)

What about flatworms?

According to Olson, the answer to these questions is always *no*: *no* animal would go with its cerebrum in a case of cerebrum transplantation.

The cerebrum is just one organ among many, not importantly different in this respect from the heart or the liver.

And that includes *human* animals (members of the species *Homo sapiens*).

What would happen to the human animal associated with you? Would it go along with its cerebrum? Would the surgeons pare that animal down to a small chunk of yellowish-pink tissue, move it across the room, and then supply it with a new head, trunk, and other parts? Surely not. A detached cerebrum is no more an organism than a detached liver is an organism. The empty-headed thing left behind, by contrast, is an animal. It may even remain alive, if the surgeons are careful to leave the lower brain intact. The empty-headed being into which your cerebrum is implanted is also an animal. It looks for all the world like there are two human animals in the story. One of them loses its cerebrum and gets an empty head. The other has its empty head filled with that organ. No animal moves from one head to another. The surgeons merely move an organ from one animal to another. (Olson, 'An Argument for Animalism', 7)

What about *us*?

You might be wondering what would happen to *you* if you were involved in a two-way cerebrum swap.

If Olson is right about animals, there are two options.

- (i) You are an animal. So, you would lose a cerebrum and gain another. You would thus undergo a massive amount of mental discontinuity—you would lose all your memories and gain a bunch of seeming-memories of the other patient's life.
- (ii) You are not an animal. Surely you are *in the same place as* a human animal—'your animal'—but the animal isn't *you*, just as the aggregate of molecules that temporarily coincides with you isn't you.

Animalism

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Some clarification about the 'we':

- ▶ Animalism is *not* the view that *all* people are animals. An animalist might think that, e.g., God is a person but not an animal, or that some AIs are people but not animals. The people he's including in his 'we' are just the familiar ones (who do things like read papers by Eric Olson).
- ▶ If anything about the first person plural is confusing, just forget about Animalism and focus on how the arguments apply to a particular example—e.g. yourself.

More on what animalism is not

Animalism is not the view that we are *essentially* animals. It does not say that none of us *could* exist without being an animal.

- ▶ It does imply this when conjoined with the further claim that *every animal is essentially an animal* (or: no animal could exist without being an animal).
- ▶ Olson (p. 3) says he is 'inclined' to accept this. But it plays no role in his argument.

The thinking animal argument

The argument

- (1) There is a human animal sitting in your chair.
- (2) Every human animal sitting in your chair is thinking.
- (3) You are the only thinking being sitting in your chair.
- (4) Hence, you are an animal.

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Sculptor unknown.

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Since the argument is indisputably valid and has three premises, there are three ways of resisting it.

Denying (1)

The first option is to deny (1) ('There is a human animal sitting in your chair').

How could this work? Presumably the view would have to be that there are no human animals—maybe no animals at all, or other organisms!

Olson mentions one possible ground someone might have for this bizarre suggestion:

Organisms, if there were such things, would constantly assimilate new particles and expel others. If nothing can survive a change of any of its parts, organisms are metaphysically impossible. What we think of as an organism is in reality only a succession of different "masses of matter" that each take on organic form for a brief moment—until a single particle is gained or lost—and then pass that form on to a numerically different mass.

But if there is this 'succession of masses of matter', why not say that we are *right* to think of it as an organism?

Denying (2)

The next option is to deny (2): ('Every human animal sitting in your chair is thinking.')

Since it would be absurd to say that, e.g., dogs can think but human animals cannot, the idea must be that *no* animals think.

Descartes perhaps thought this—he at least thought that nonhuman animals such as dogs were mere 'automata', without minds, and consequently without beliefs, hopes, etc.

But this view seems obviously wrong to anyone who interacts with animals a bit. It also looks philosophically hopeless if we do not accept Descartes' posit of immaterial souls.

Denying (3)

The most interesting way of blocking the argument is to deny (3) ('You are the only thinking being sitting in your chair').

The idea is that whenever you are sitting in a chair and thinking, there are *at least two* thinking things sitting in that chair.

- ▶ Some will think it's way more than two. On Lewis's view, the number of thinking things sitting in the chair will be enormous, plausibly *infinite*!
- ▶ But even having two is very weird!

An epistemological argument

If there really are two beings, a person and an animal, now thinking your thoughts and performing your actions, you ought to wonder which one you are. You may think you're the person (the one that isn't an animal). But doesn't the animal think that it is a person too? It has all the same reasons for thinking so as you have. Yet it is mistaken. If you were the animal and not the person, you'd still think you were the person. So for all you know, you're the one making the mistake. Even if you are a person and not an animal, you could never have any reason to believe that you are. (Olson, 12)

This seems to be an appeal to the idea that knowledge requires 'safely true belief': one's true belief that p is not knowledge if there is a *close* (or 'relevant') possibility of error.

An epistemological argument

The epistemological argument can be resisted by denying that the animal thinks it isn't an animal (assuming you think you're not an animal).

The idea is that when the animal says 'I', it does not refer to itself, but rather refers to you. And the same is true for its 'first-person' *thoughts*.

If no thinker in the situation is making any mistakes, then there is no obvious threat to the status of the true beliefs as knowledge.

An ethical argument?

Some (Olson, Johnston) have given *ethical* arguments against the view that every person coincides with other thinking things.

The idea is that if there were these other thinking things, they would have *rights*, just like any other thinking things. But this seems to lead to ethically absurd results, at least if those other thinking things have variable persistence conditions.

- For example, Olson and Johnston suggest that it implies that it is morally impermissible to put oneself through unpleasant experiences for the sake of later payoffs, since some of those other thinking things will have to endure the unpleasant experiences but won't be around for the payoffs.

The problem of remnants

The remnant case

Consider the following case: a cerebrum is extracted from a normal human body. It is temporarily placed in a tank, and hooked up using electrodes to a robotic body so that it can interact. It persists in this condition for some time, interacting with family members of the original human being, etc. Then after some months, a suitable 'host' is found—a person who suffered 'brain death'—and the cerebrum is transplanted and hooked up to the new body.



Fallout (Amazon MGM Studios, 2024).

Claims about the remnant case

It seems very clear that during the period when the cerebrum is not in any body, there is *a* thinking thing whose thoughts correlate with what's going on in the cerebrum. Maybe it's the cerebrum itself, or maybe something distinct from it but coincident with it.

NB Olson is not committed to denying this! Animalism is not the view that *all* people are animals. In a world where there was a substantial population of 'robobrain' tooling around and buying philosophy books, Olson wouldn't have been so confident in his uses of the first person plural and second person singular.

The problem

But Olson *is* committed to the view that the cerebrum-person *only recently began* to be a thinker (assuming it's a thinker at all). Its 'memories' of a normal human childhood are misleading—*it* was never a child. Before the recent operation, the only relevant thinking thing was the human animal that is now lying, cerebrum-less, in a vegetative state.

More disturbingly, he seems to be committed to the view that the cerebrum-person *will cease to be* a thinker when the cerebrum is transplanted into a new host. For at that point, the animal into which it was transplanted will start to think again. And surely Olson cannot say that *this* animal, unlike ordinary human animals that are never involved in transplantation operations, will share its thoughts with a thinking non-animal.